PassFrame
TUITION

The Locked Door in the Orchard Wall

Year 5 — 11+ Homework Worksheet (PassFrame Tuition)

Comprehension | Fiction

Extract — read it carefully before answering

Eleanor had lived at Thornfield Hall for three weeks before she discovered the wall. It ran along the far edge of the orchard, half-swallowed by ivy, its old red bricks crumbling gently in the autumn light. She might never have noticed it at all, had a robin not perched on top of it one morning and seemed, quite deliberately, to be waiting for her.

She followed the wall for almost a hundred paces before she found it: a door, so completely covered in dead ivy that it looked more like a tangle of roots than anything built by human hands. The handle was rusted nearly solid, and a heavy padlock hung from a chain, its keyhole clogged with years of dirt.

Eleanor pressed her eye to a gap where the wood had split. Beyond, she could just make out a garden gone entirely wild — rose bushes grown as tall as trees, grass standing in golden waves, and, at the very centre, a stone fountain, silent and dry, its basin filled with drifted leaves.

Nobody at Thornfield Hall had ever mentioned a garden behind the orchard wall. When Eleanor asked the old gardener, Mr Hodge, his face changed in a way she could not quite name, and he told her sharply to keep away from that corner of the grounds.

But that night, lying awake and listening to the wind rattling the windowpanes, Eleanor could think of nothing else. Somewhere beyond that locked door was a garden that time itself seemed to have forgotten — and she was quite determined to find a way in.

Questions

25 min · 12 questions

1. Where exactly was the wall that Eleanor discovered?

2. How many paces did Eleanor follow the wall before finding the door?

3. Underline the sentence that tells you the padlock could not easily be opened.

4. Underline the sentence that shows Eleanor could not stop thinking about the garden.

5. What does “crumbling” suggest about the condition of the bricks?

6. Put these events in order: Eleanor asks Mr Hodge about the garden / Eleanor finds the door / Eleanor follows the wall / Eleanor lies awake thinking about the garden.

7. Why might the author have chosen a robin to lead Eleanor to the wall?

8. What was blocking the padlock's keyhole?

9. How does Mr Hodge's reaction make the garden seem more mysterious?

10. What does the word “determined” at the end of the extract tell you about Eleanor's character?

11. Find and copy a word that means “extremely stubbornly decided”.

12. Why do you think the author chose to end the extract on Eleanor's determination rather than her finding a way in? What effect does this have on the reader?